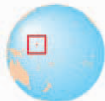


Nauru



Nauru lies in the Pacific, northeast of Australia. Phosphate deposits gave its inhabitants huge temporary wealth, but economic mismanagement has left them facing ruin.



GEOGRAPHY

A single low-lying coral atoll, with a fertile coastal belt. Coral cliffs encircle an elevated interior plateau.



CLIMATE

Equatorial, moderated by sea breezes. Occasional long droughts.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Native Nauruans are of mixed Micronesian and Polynesian origin. Most live in simple, traditional houses and spend their money on luxury cars and consumer goods. Welfare and education are free. A diet of imported processed foods has caused widespread obesity and diabetes. Mining was left to imported laborers, mainly from Kiribati, who lived in enclaves of male-only barracks and had few rights. Many young Nauruans leave to seek a better life in Australia or New Zealand.



THE ECONOMY

Phosphate revenues all but dried up. Sale of fishing rights sole resource. State trust fund invested badly overseas. Offshore banking facilities closed after international pressure.



INSIGHT: *Phosphate mining has left 80% of the island uninhabitable*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Nauru

DATE OF FORMATION: 1968

CAPITAL: None

POPULATION: 9800

TOTAL AREA: 8.1 sq. miles

(21 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1210 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Nauruan*, Kiribati, Chinese, Tuvaluan, English

RELIGIONS: Nauruan Congregational Church 60%, Catholic 35%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Nauruan 62%, other Pacific islanders 27%, Asian 8%, European 3%

GOVERNMENT: Nonparty system

CURRENCY: Australian dollar = 100 cents